extensive installations allowed US forces to project power, intervene when necessary, and provide a constant level of insurance and security for public goods such as freedom of navigation; they also served as the major bases for America's Vietnam War efforts. While concerned about communist subversion of Asian countries, Washington did not face a significant traditional great-power challenge in Asia's common seas or skies throughout these decades. The major American military priorities were to prevent another North Korean attack across the thirty-eighth parallel and to bottle up Soviet ballistic missile submarines in their littoral bastions in the Sea of Okhotsk and nearby waters; this latter was undertaken in conjunction particularly with Japanese naval and air forces.

As Asian economies took off in the 1960s and 1970s, beginning with Japan and then spreading to the "Four Tigers" of South Korea, Singapore, Hong Kong, and Taiwan, an economic element to Asia's strategic importance came to the fore. As America's economy became more tied to Asian manufacturers, concern with ensuring freedom of navigation and the high seas, and protecting crucial lanes of sea transport, concurrently rose in importance. Subsidiary to that was a growing US interest in ensuring overall stability in Asia, so that the economies of key allies such as Japan and South Korea were not threatened by external aggression or internal upheaval. The rise of Asia during the final decades of the Cold War occasioned the melding of geoeconomic interests with long-standing geopolitical and security interests, but the region was still treated in many ways as simply one part of a global anti-Soviet/anticommunist grand strategy.

American Strategy in the Indo-Pacific after the Cold War and the Rise of China

Contemporaneous with the collapse of the Soviet Union and the bursting of the Japanese economic bubble at the beginning of the 1990s, China began its unprecedented rise to global power. During the Cold